own and at what stage do they send them to the PMO for decision. Diplomats assert that it is often a judgement call based on one's experience. 'How does the doctor know when to do this or that?' observed a foreign service officer, adding, 'they learn through experience and from their seniors.' Routine matters are disposed of at a junior level within the hierarchy while sensitive issues require attention up the chain of command. Careers are destroyed by errors of judgement in assuming a question is unimportant when later it becomes crucial.

Some diplomats deny that the relationship between the PMO and the Ministry of External Affairs is in any way competitive. According to the official version, the ministry's role is to serve the political leadership. The job of civil servants is only to list options for the prime minister along with their opinion as to the most practical course under given circumstances. In reality, permanent civil servants in the Ministry of External Affairs often complain that with decision making increasingly centred in the Prime Minister's Office, the bureaucracy's role is only to take blame for mistakes or public relations disasters. An increasing number of interest groups – political parties, state governments, local elites, corporate groups and media – now exert influence on foreign policy, primarily through political channels that influence the prime minister. The civil service in the MEA sees this as intrusion in their sphere, insisting that apolitical bureaucrats are better suited to make above- board choices and decisions on merit.

The appointment of a national security adviser since 1999 is designed as an institutional bridge between the foreign service, intelligence services and the PMO. Now, the Indian national security apparatus approximates the American model. It comprises the national security adviser (NSA), the National Security Council Secretariat (NSCS) led by the deputy national security adviser and the National Security Advisory Board (NSAB) that enables unofficial voices on foreign policy to be heard by the government.